

# AFRICA, HISTORY OF



CIVILIZATION IN AFRICA BEGAN TO appear more than 5,000 years ago with the rise of ancient Egypt. From about 2,500 years ago in sub-Saharan Africa, many other different kingdoms also developed. The

Sahara acted as a barrier to keep this area separate from the rest of the world until the arrival of Arab traders in the 8th century. From the 15th century, the arrival of Europeans, the subsequent slave trade, and European imperialism had a profound effect on the continent. Since the 1950s, all African nations have reclaimed independence, although modern Africa continues to struggle with its post-colonial legacy and environmental problems.



## Ancient empires

North Africa was in a good position to trade with western Asia. This caused rich empires to develop, including Meroë (modern Sudan, c.600 BC–AD 350), and Aksum (a trading state in northern Ethiopia, c.100 BC–AD 1000). Ghana (in West Africa, c.500–1300) developed for similar reasons.

### Meroë

From the city of Meroë, the Kushites controlled trade in the Red Sea and the Nile River from 600 BC. They exported luxury goods, such as ostrich feathers and leopard skins, and built fine temples and flat-topped pyramids over the graves of their dead.

Ruined temple, Meroë

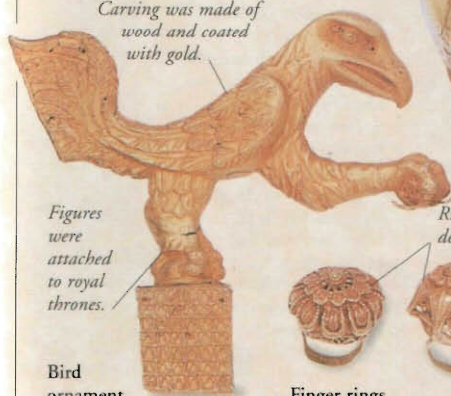


### Ghana

Ghana (located on the borders of modern Mali and Mauritania), one of Africa's most important empires, controlled the trans-Saharan trade in gold. Ghana's kings wore gold jewellery, and gold-embroidered clothes and turbans. Surviving gold artefacts show the incredible wealth of this kingdom.

Heads of gold, often of royalty, played an important part in rituals.

Carving was made of wood and coated with gold.



Figures were attached to royal thrones.

Bird ornament



Head weighs 1.5 kg (3 lbs).

Rings were often decorated with flowers.

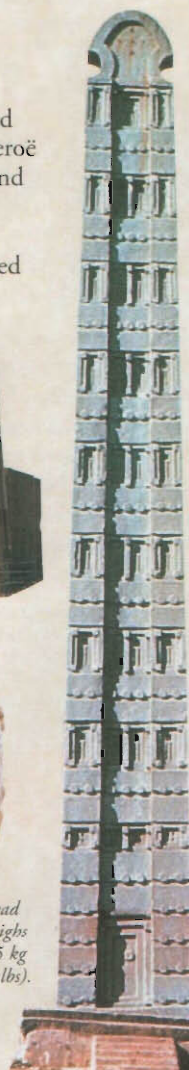


Finger rings

### Aksum

From c.300, Egyptian scholars introduced Christianity to Aksum, which then became famous as a holy city. During this period, Aksum took over the empire based at Meroë. Aksum's people built tall, stone stelae (monuments) to mark the tombs of dead kings.

Stela, Aksum

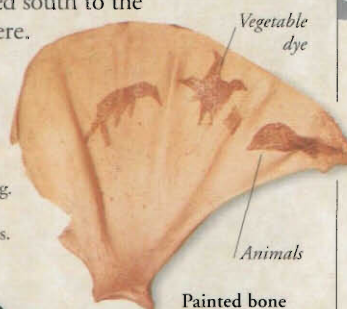


## Early inhabitants

Humans have inhabited Africa for 4 million years. The Sahara was once a fertile land rich in plants and animals. But thousands of years ago, it dried up, and people moved south to the savannah to farm there.

### Rock paintings

Rock and bone pictures often depicted everyday events, such as dancing, hunting animals, and fishing. Painters used animal fat coloured with vegetable dyes.



Vegetable dye

Animals

Painted bone



### Nok culture

The earliest evidence of Iron Age settlement is called the Nok culture (500 BC–AD 200), which existed in what is now central Nigeria. Nok people lived in farming communities. They made iron weapons and tools for farming, and also produced fine terracotta sculptures.

Terracotta head, Nok culture

## Spread of religions

From the 8th century, trade, conquests, and colonialism spread religions such as Islam in Africa. In North Africa, Islam completely replaced traditional religions, which often included the worship of ancestors.

### Ancestor worship

In many parts of Africa, communities had sacred shrines where they placed offerings for the spirits of their dead ancestors. Today, during certain annual festivals, members of the community wear special masks, sing, dance, and tell stories in honour of their ancestors.

Festival mask



### Islam

By c.800, Middle Eastern Arabs had taken Islam to North Africa. From the 11th century, trade helped spread Islam across the Sahara into West Africa and up the River Nile into Sudan.

Ait Benhaddou, Morocco

### Slave trade

By the 1470s, the Portuguese were trading copper, brass, gold, and slaves with Benin in West Africa. In the 1480s, the Portuguese arrived in the islands of Principe and São Tomé in the Gulf of Guinea, just off the west African coast. They established sugar plantations, and forced African captives (mainly kidnapped in Senegal and Gambia) to work as slaves on the plantations. This was the beginning of European domination in Africa.

Plaque showing Portuguese soldier, 1500s

